

Warmer and longer growing seasons increase growth for juvenile trees in a common garden

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Abstract

Anthropogenic climate change affects natural systems at the global scale. The most frequently observed biological impact of climate change—shifts in the timing of recurring life history events (phenology)—is likely to have additional effects. For trees, shifted phenology has extended the vegetative growing season, which is widely expected to increase tree growth, with important effects on forest carbon sequestration. However, multiple recent studies found that tree growth and growing season length were decoupled and suggested shifts in drought or competition may prevent increased growth. Here, we address this decoupling in a drought- and competition-limited system by leveraging a unique dataset of annual vegetative phenology and growth (via tree rings) of juvenile tree data from a common garden of four species within the *Betulaceae* family sourced from four provenances. We found an overall positive response to warmer seasons for our juvenile trees (three out of four species) with a weaker response to longer seasons, emphasizing the importance of growing conditions above the season length alone. We further showed little effect of provenance on growth, suggesting that previous findings on population-level differences as predictors for assembly models under future climate change may not be as useful as previously suggested. In addition, most species showed a stronger response to the end of season than the start of season. This suggests that we should look beyond the start of season in future tree growth studies and that we need to consider species differences more in such studies to better feed into vegetation and related earth system models. Then, our results suggest that juvenile trees may benefit from warmer seasons with climate change leading to potential benefits for forest regeneration and range expansion.

Introduction

The most frequently observed biological impact of climate change is shifts in phenology—the timing of recurring life history events (Parmesan *et al.*, 1999; Menzel *et al.*, 2006; Calvin *et al.*, 2023). Across many plant species, spring events have advanced (Wolfe *et al.*, 2005; Chmielewski & Rötzer, 2001; Fu *et al.*, 2014), while autumn events have delayed—but to a lesser extent (Gallinat *et al.*, 2015; Jeong & Medvigy, 2014). Together, early springs and later autumns lengthen the growing season, which should increase growth for many species, including trees (Keenan *et al.*, 2014; Stridbeck *et al.*, 2022).

How much trees increase growth with longer seasons is important given the major role of forests in carbon sequestration (Friedlingstein *et al.*, 2026). Temperate forests account for roughly 40% of the annual global carbon sink, diminishing the consequences of human-emitted greenhouse gas emissions on the climate (Gibbs *et al.*, 2025). With warming, research has repeatedly found a connection between longer seasons and increased carbon storage (Boisvenue & Running, 2006; Gao *et al.*, 2022; Finzi *et al.*, 2020).

The future of this net carbon sink by temperate forests, however, relies on the assumption that longer and warmer seasons will keep increasing carbon storage by trees (Pan *et al.*, 2024). A shift in this relationship could impact the future of this critical carbon sink. It could also limit the utility of forestry-related climate

solutions which aim to mitigate climate change through the restoration and management of forests (Cook-Patton *et al.*, 2020). These solutions could be better informed through better forecasts of tree growth with future climate change. This requires, however, that we increase our understanding of the mechanisms driving tree growth with a more nuanced view of these processes across a wider range of species and biomes. Ultimately, this could help target the conservation and restoration of forests in specific ecosystems to optimize land carbon storage (Ruehr *et al.*, 2023; Chang *et al.*, 2024).

New studies suggest that longer growing seasons do not always increase growth (Dow *et al.*, 2022; Silvestro *et al.*, 2023; Matula *et al.*, 2023; Charlet De Sauvage *et al.*, 2022; Cabon *et al.*, 2022). Recently, Dow *et al.* (2022) found that warmer springs lengthened the growing season, but did not increase the peak growth rate or total annual growth in two temperate forest communities. Working across biomes, Cabon *et al.* (2022) found a similar trend, where gross primary production and growth appeared decoupled. However, neither of these studies could clearly establish why they found no relationship while previous studies have. Understanding whether temperate forests will persist as a net carbon sink requires answering why trees do not grow more despite longer growing seasons.

A longer growing season does not necessarily mean more favorable thermal conditions for growth. While the well-documented advance of spring phenology elongates the growing season (Keenan *et al.*, 2014), spring days are short and usually cool (Figure 1a). Therefore, this advance may contribute little to a tree’s annual growing degree days (GDD) accumulation (Figure 1b). In contrast, even small shifts to later end of season events can lead to larger changes in annual GDD; since more GDD accumulates per day during this period, any extra end of season days may be more important than additional start of season days (Buonaiuto *et al.*, 2026).

Other factors beyond the thermal conditions may affect whether longer seasons increase growth. While trees may have a longer period to grow, water availability may become insufficient to support continuous growth throughout the growing season (Wang *et al.*, 2025). Competition for light and nutrients may further limit the capacity of trees to benefit from longer seasons, especially for the ones positioned below the forest canopy (Cleland & Wolkovich, 2024; Augspurger & Bartlett, 2003; Sweeney *et al.*, 2024). Additionally, trees may have internal constraints that prevent them from increasing growth with longer seasons. Growth, like other biological processes, is under strict genetic control. Thus, even with optimal environmental conditions, physiological constraints may prevent temperate trees from growing indefinitely (Körner *et al.*, 2023; Wolkovich *et al.*, 2025), but we currently have a limited understanding of how well tree phenology and growth can track changing conditions.

Current research suggests that leaf and wood phenology differ in their plasticity in response to changing environmental conditions across species and life stages (Dox *et al.*, 2022). Leaf phenology (e.g. leafout) in the spring is a highly plastic trait with substantial variation across years with different climates, and also across species. Within a single community leafout can vary across species by over a month, with a general trend of species with more conservative growth strategies leafing out later (Loughnan *et al.*, 2025). Additionally, leaf phenology and growth appear closely synchronized in diffuse-porous species (e.g., *Betula*; Čufar *et al.*, 2008) and less so in ring-porous species (e.g., *Oaks*; González-González *et al.*, 2013), making leaf phenology a good proxy for setting the start and end of the growing season in diffuse-porous species (Marchand *et al.*, 2021; Silvestro *et al.*, 2025; Suzuki *et al.*, 1996). While this proxy is useful for setting the boundaries of the growing season, it does not indicate how much trees grow annually. How flexible growth is in response to changing growing season length and conditions varies between species and populations, and may also differ with tree age, with juvenile trees being generally more flexible and responsive than their adult forms (Augspurger & Bartlett, 2003; Way & Montgomery, 2015).

Local adaptation could limit tree growth responses of different populations to future climate change (Soolanayakanahally *et al.*, 2013; Wolkovich *et al.*, 2025). While leaf phenology (e.g. leafout) in the spring is highly plastic and driven by temperature, end of season phenology (e.g. budset) is much less plastic and mostly driven by photoperiod (Baumgarten *et al.*, 2026; Singh *et al.*, 2017), with evidence of local adaptation (Zeng & Wolkovich, 2024). Provenance trials have repeatedly found trees from northern latitudes set bud earlier, even when grown in warm climates with longer growing seasons (Aitken & Bemmels, 2016; Way & Montgomery, 2015). This local adaptation and related reliance on photoperiod to trigger budset (an end of season event)

likely explains why shifts in the end of season with warming have been so much smaller than shifts in the start of season (Piao *et al.*, 2019). This predicts a latitudinal gradient in growth responses, with more limited responses in poleward populations where the end of season is constrained to happen earlier in the season. Thus, common gardens investigating the effect of provenance latitude could help predict how climate change will affect tree growth.

To understand the relationship between growing seasons and growth, we need to understand how growth varies across species and populations while disentangling how much longer seasons are also more thermally favorable seasons. Here, we address this by studying how growth and growing seasons relate across species, populations and multiple metrics of growing season length. Working with juvenile trees sourced from four populations and grown in one common garden, we examine how growth, measured via tree rings, and leaf phenology covary over three years. We consider effects of both the length of the season (i.e. number of growing days in the season) and its thermal conditions (i.e. GDD accumulated in the season).

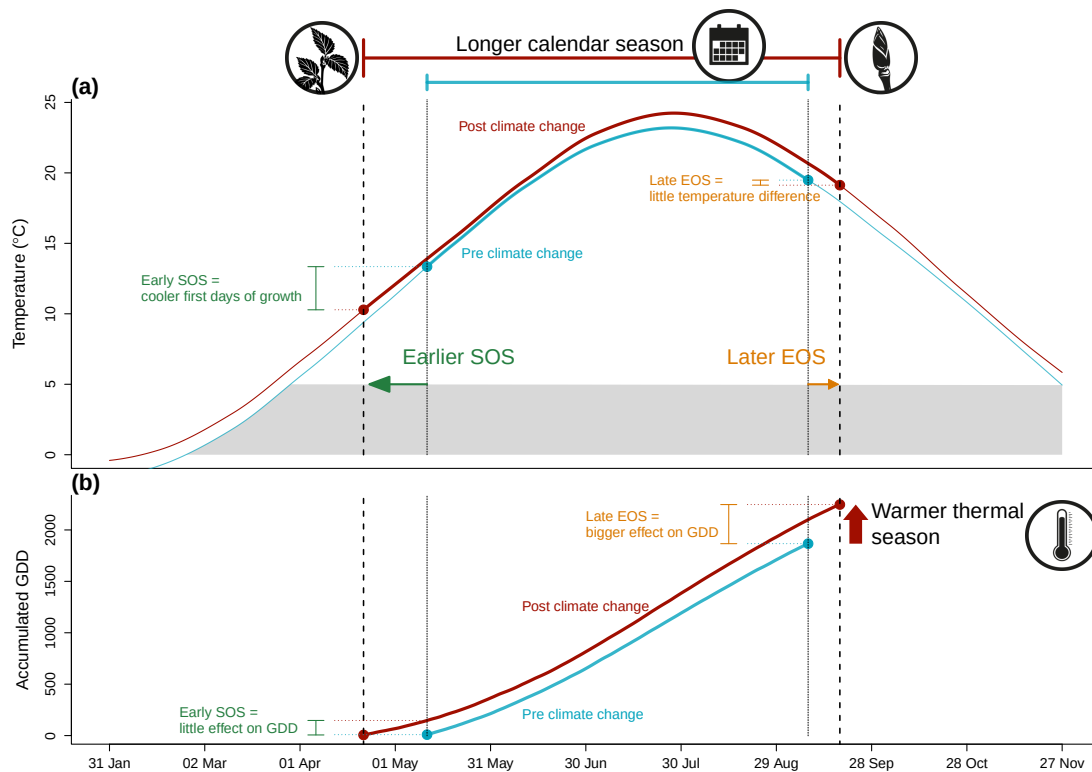


Figure 1: Shifting growing season lengths with climate change affect both the temperature trees experience throughout the growing season (a), and how many growing degree days (GDD) they accumulate (b). Here we show changes in daily (smoothed) and accumulated temperatures before (1945-1965, in blue) and significant anthropogenic climate warming (2005-2025, in red) using data local to our study. The arrows represent hypothetical shifts in spring (green) and autumn (orange) phenology. With climate change, spring events have advanced and autumn phenology has delayed, but to a much lesser extent—lengthening the calendar growing season. This concurrently changed the temperature trees experience early in their season, with cooler first days of growth (a) causing little accumulation of GDD (b). In contrast, weaker shifts in the end of season and little temperature change (a) result in a relatively high GDD accumulation (b) due to warmer temperature at this time of the season. Alongside these start and end of season shifts, warmer summer temperatures increased GDD accumulation, further warming their thermal seasons. We used mean daily temperature data from the Boston Logan International Airport Climate Station for the smoothed temperature and GDD curves (National Oceanic and Atmospheric Administration (NOAA), 2026).

Materials and Methods

Common garden setup and data collection

We collected seeds from 18 species of deciduous trees and shrubs from four provenances across a 3.5° latitudinal gradient (Figure 2; Table S1) in 2014-2015, germinated them following standard germination protocols and grew them to seedlings (Baskin & Baskin, 2014). In the spring of 2017, we planted the seedlings outside at the Weld Hill Research Building at the Arnold Arboretum in Boston MA (42.30°N, 71.13°W). Plots were regularly weeded and watered throughout the duration of the study and were pruned in the autumn of 2020 (Buonaiuto *et al.*, 2026).

For the years 2018-2020, we monitored leaf phenology for all individuals in the common garden once or twice per week from February to December; the exact frequency varied within and across years (for more details, see Figure S1). For this, we used a modified BBCH scale to observe two phenological stages: leafout which we defined as: BBCH 15 and budset as BBCH 102; (Finn *et al.*, 2007; Buonaiuto *et al.*, 2026). We had a total of 239 leafout and 230 budset observations (which we refer to as the ‘full datasets’), but for some individual trees in certain years we did not have both events; thus our total of matched full growing season duration (which we refer to as the ‘restricted dataset’) is 227 observations.

In the spring of 2023, we collected tree ring samples from tree species with high survivorship. Thus, we have four species in the *Betulaceae* family : Grey alder (*Alnus incana*), Yellow birch (*Betula alleghaniensis*), Paper birch (*Betula papyrifera*) and Grey birch (*Betula populifolia*). We collected cross-sections on 78 individuals by cutting the trunk above the root collar, and cores on 43 individuals using standard dendrochronological methods (Cook & Kairiukstis, 1990), for a total of 81 individual trees (Table S1). We stored the cores in modified plastic straws to promote aeration and left them to dry with the cross-sections at ambient temperature for three months.

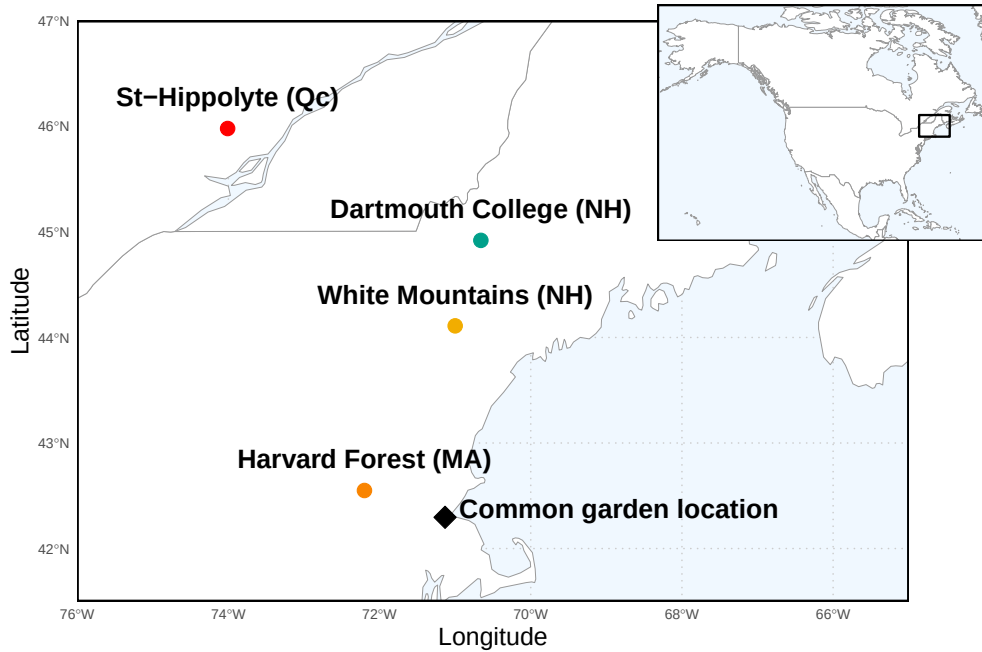


Figure 2: Provenance where the seeds were sourced from is depicted as circles, while the diamond denotes the location of the common garden. The common garden location is where the study took place at the Weld Research Building (Boston, MA). The colors of the dots match the model estimates of Figure 4.

Sample processing, imaging and measuring

We mounted cores on wooden mounts and sanded both the cores and cross-sections using progressively finer sandpaper grits (150, 300, 400, 600, 800, 1000), then scanned the cores and cross-sections at a resolution of 6250 dpi with a high-resolution tree ring scanner (Fong *et al.*, 2026). Using the digitized images, we measured ring widths with ImageJ (Schneider *et al.*, 2012) at three standard locations for each cross-section (at 120° from each other, averaging the three measurements to yield one ring width per year, per individual), and one ring width for each core. When we had cross-sections ($n = 78$) and cores ($n = 43$) for an individual, we used only the measurement from the cross-sections ($n = 81$).

We performed visual cross dating. This consists of assigning a calendar year to each ring and comparing the year-to-year growth variation and anomalies across replicates of the same species (Cook & Kairiukstis, 1990). We did not perform statistical crossdating or detrending because our chronologies (number of years of data) were extremely short (Raden *et al.*, 2020) and showed no evidence of consistent allometric trends (Figure S2). We controlled for effects of different years by including ‘year’ in our models (see equation 1 in ‘Data analyses’ below).

Data analyses

To understand how growth shifted with season length, we used Bayesian hierarchical models, estimating how growth, measured as ring width, covaried with season length, measured in four different ways: GDD, GSL, SOS and EOS. We calculated the thermal season using growing degree days (GDD; mean daily temperature above 5°C) accumulated between leafout and budset, and the calendar season (or growing season length; GSL) as the number of days between leafout and budset. Finally, we used leafout for the start of season (SOS) and budset for the end of the season (EOS) as separate predictors that represent the boundaries of the growing season. For interpretability, we report ring width change in % with the number of GDDs accumulated in an average week (seven days) in May (day of year 121 to 150 from 2018 to 2020), for the thermal season, and ring width change per week of season length, leafout and budset for GSL, SOS and EOS, respectively. We report effects when the 90% UI do not overlap with zero and consider a trend if the 50% UI do not overlap with zero.

For daily climate data across all the years of phenological sampling (2018-2020), we combined two sources. For 2018 and 2019, we used data from the climate station located at Weld Hill research station (Arnold Arboretum, 2026). Because the data were not available for that station after August 2020, we used data from the weather station ‘Boston (Weld Hill)’ of the Network for Environment and Weather Applications (NEWA) for the whole year in 2020 (Carroll *et al.*, 2026). We used the North American Drought Monitor Maps to determine drought occurrence across years at our study location and used the proposed drought intensity index to qualify the presence of moderate, severe or extreme droughts (National Centers for Environmental Information (NCEI), 2026).

For each predictor, we estimated its effect on observed ring width (i , denoting each observation) for each tree ($treeid$) in each year ($year$) as:

$$\begin{aligned} \ln(ringwidth)_i &\sim Normal(\mu, \sigma_y) \\ \mu &= \alpha + \alpha_{species} + \alpha_{prov} + \alpha_{treeid} + \alpha_{year} + \beta_{species} \times \text{season predictor} \\ \alpha_{prov} &\sim Normal(0, \sigma_{\alpha_{prov}}) \\ \alpha_{treeid} &\sim Normal(0, \sigma_{\alpha_{treeid}}) \end{aligned} \tag{1}$$

This model estimates a species-specific effect of each season length predictor (e.g. GDD) on growth ($\beta_{species}$), while also controlling for other variation due to species ($\alpha_{species}$), provenance (α_{prov}), individual tree (α_{treeid}) and year (α_{year}). We ran the models using both natural units, and also using scaled predictors (via z -scoring, Gelman & Hill, 2006) to allow for direct comparison of effect sizes across different metrics. We report estimates as means and 90% uncertainty intervals (UI).

We used weakly informative priors for all models (increasing the priors by $2\times$ for the z -scored models did not qualitatively affect the results). We ran four chains with 2000 warm-up and 2000 sampling iterations each,

for a total of 8000 sampling iterations and checked output diagnostics: chains had no divergent transitions, $\hat{R}$ values below 1.01, and effective sample sizes (n_{eff}) greater than 10% of the model iterations. We also fit the models for SOS and EOS using both the restricted ($n = 227$) and full datasets for each predictor (SOS $n = 239$ and EOS $n = 230$). We wrote our models using Stan (Carpenter *et al.*, 2017) with the rstan package version 2.32.7 (Stan Development Team, 2025) to run the Stan code in R.

In addition, we compared the relative effect of an extension in the SOS versus EOS using our estimated effect of GDD (Equation 1). To do this, we averaged the GDD (mean daily GDD from 2005 to 2025) accumulated seven days before the median leafout (for SOS) and after the median budset (for EOS), for each species, across all years of our dataset. Then, with our estimated parameters, we report the % effect of GDD on growth for an extended SOS and EOS: $\% \Delta \text{ring width} = (e^{\beta * \text{GDD}_{\text{extSOS/EOS}}} - 1) \times 100$.

Because ring widths decrease with age—particularly with young trees—we also ran the models using basal area increment (BAI) as the response variable. This allows for a more representative portrayal of annual growth increment by using the total ring area, instead of its width alone. To calculate BAI we summed each ring width separately at the three distinct locations on the cross sections yielding three radii from pit to bark. We then calculated the area of each ring by subtracting the radius from the inner ring from the outer ring: $\pi \times (\text{inner radius}^2 - \text{outer radius}^2)$, and averaged across the three BAI for each ring.

Results

Our dataset comprised four deciduous tree species from four sites with leaf phenology data spanning three years (2018 to 2020) for a total of 239 leafout and 230 budset observations, yielding 227 complete growing seasons for 81 individuals. At the common garden location, the mean summer temperature was similar across years, with 2019 being the coolest (22.38°C), 2020 the hottest (23.07°C), and 2018 in between (22.85°C). There was no drought for those three years, except in 2020, when a moderate summer drought (June-August) ramped up to a severe drought in September (National Centers for Environmental Information (NCEI), 2026). The calendar and thermal seasons ranged from 90 days and 1465.1 GDD (*B. alleghaniensis* in 2018) to 173 days and 2513.6 GDD (*A. incana* in 2018; Figure S8a and b). The earliest leafout was 22-Apr (*A. incana* in 2019) and the latest, 05-Jun (also *A. incana*, but in 2020; Figure S8c). The earliest budset was 13-Aug (*B. alleghaniensis* in 2018) and the latest, 24-Oct (*A. incana* in 2018; Figure S8d). Finally, annual ring widths across years varied from 0.39 mm (*B. alleghaniensis* in 2020) to 13.55 mm (*B. populifolia* in 2018; Figure S7).

Longer growing seasons increased growth for all species, but varied depending on the metric used to measure it. We report estimates as means and 90% uncertainty intervals (UI) that correspond to ring width change in % per one week unit (see ‘Data analyses’ section in Methods for more details). Warmer thermal seasons increased growth for Paper birch (*Betula papyrifera*; $\beta = 16.08\%$ (UI: 6.26, 26.42)), Grey birch (*Betula populifolia*; $\beta = 7.23\%$ (UI: 2.50, 12.22)), and Yellow birch (*Betula alleghaniensis*; $\beta = 4.27\%$ (UI: 0.56, 8.08)). Grey alder (*Alnus incana*) trended in the same direction ($\beta = 2.20\%$ (UI: -1.08, 5.55)); Figure 3a and e; TableS2). Unlike its response to warmer thermal season, *A. incana* grew more with longer calendar seasons ($\beta = 5.22\%$ (UI: 0.18, 10.39)). *B. papyrifera* also grew more with longer calendar seasons ($\beta = 20.67\%$ (UI: 5.59, 36.64)), while the other two *Betula* did not, though they trended in the same way (*B. alleghaniensis*: $\beta = 3.35\%$ (UI: -2.95, 9.73), and *B. populifolia*: $\beta = 5.74\%$ (UI: -1.96, 13.87); Figure 3b and f; Table S3). On a scaled axis (through z-scoring, Gelman & Hill, 2006), the thermal and calendar season were similarly predictive (Figure S9). Results with basal area increment (BAI) for the GDD model were similar to ring width (see Table S6).

Increased growth with longer seasons is often presumed to come from growth in the spring, since spring phenology has shifted much more than autumn phenology. Yet, we found most species grew more with a later end of season, and only one species grew more with an earlier start of season (*A. incana* (one of the two species for which a longer calendar season increased growth: $\beta = -7.00\%$ (UI: -12.51, -1.16); Figure 3c and g; Table S3). *B. populifolia* trended in the opposite direction ($\beta = 5.17\%$ (UI: -6.55, 17.51); Figure 3c and g; Table S5). *B. alleghaniensis*, which did not grow more with a longer calendar season, grew less with an earlier start of season ($\beta = 10.63\%$ (UI: 0.34, 21.50); Figure 3c and g; Table S4)—but more with a later

end of season ($\beta = 12.22\%$ (UI: 5.16, 19.41)). Alongside *B. alleghaniensis*, two other species grew more with a later end of season (*B. populifolia*: $\beta = 10.03\%$ (UI: 2.14, 18.09), and *B. papyrifera*: $\beta = 23.74\%$ (UI: 9.37, 39.20); Figure 3d and h; Table S5), with the latter being the only one of those three that also grew more with longer calendar season. The estimates were unchanged when using the full (SOS: $n = 239$ and EOS: $n = 230$) or restricted datasets ($n = 227$; Figure S3a).

These results suggest that a later EOS contributes more to growth than an earlier start of season, which could be due to the warmer days at the end of the season. Supporting this, we found that the addition of an estimated 7 days at the EOS increased growth across all species by 10.69% (UI: 6.11, 15.48), compared to an increase of 7.16% (UI: 4.10, 10.31) from an earlier SOS (estimated using our model of GDD shown in Figure 3, see ‘Data analyses’ section in Methods for more details; Table S7). Differences in magnitude between an extension of SOS versus EOS were similar across species (Table S7).

We did not find any clear effect of year on growth (2018: $\alpha = 0.17$ (UI: -0.77, 1.14) ring width (log(mm); henceforth ‘RW’); 2019: $\alpha = 0.16$ (UI: -0.78, 1.12) RW; 2020: $\alpha = -0.45$ (UI: -1.39, 0.51) RW; Table S2), and there were no apparent differences in baseline growth between species (*A. incana*: $\alpha = 1.01\%$ (UI: -3.14, 5.18) RW; *B. alleghaniensis*: $\alpha = 0.15\%$ (UI: -4.04, 4.24) RW; *B. papyrifera*: $\alpha = -4.04\%$ (UI: -9.02, 0.89) RW; *B. populifolia*: $\alpha = -0.70\%$ (UI: -5.04, 3.50) RW; Figure S4 and S5; Table S2). In addition, growth did not vary with provenance (Dartmouth College (NH): $\alpha = -0.03$ (UI: -0.22, 0.15) RW; Harvard Forest (MA): $\alpha = -0.10$ (UI: -0.33, 0.07) RW; St-Hippolyte (Qc): $\alpha = 0.04$ (UI: -0.14, 0.26) RW; White Mountains (NH): $\alpha = 0.08$ (UI: -0.08, 0.30) RW; Figure 4; Table S2). The limited variation between provenances ($\sigma = 0.18$ (UI: 0.02, 0.48 RW) was similar to variation across individual trees ($\sigma = 0.17$ (UI: 0.05, 0.27) RW; Table S2).

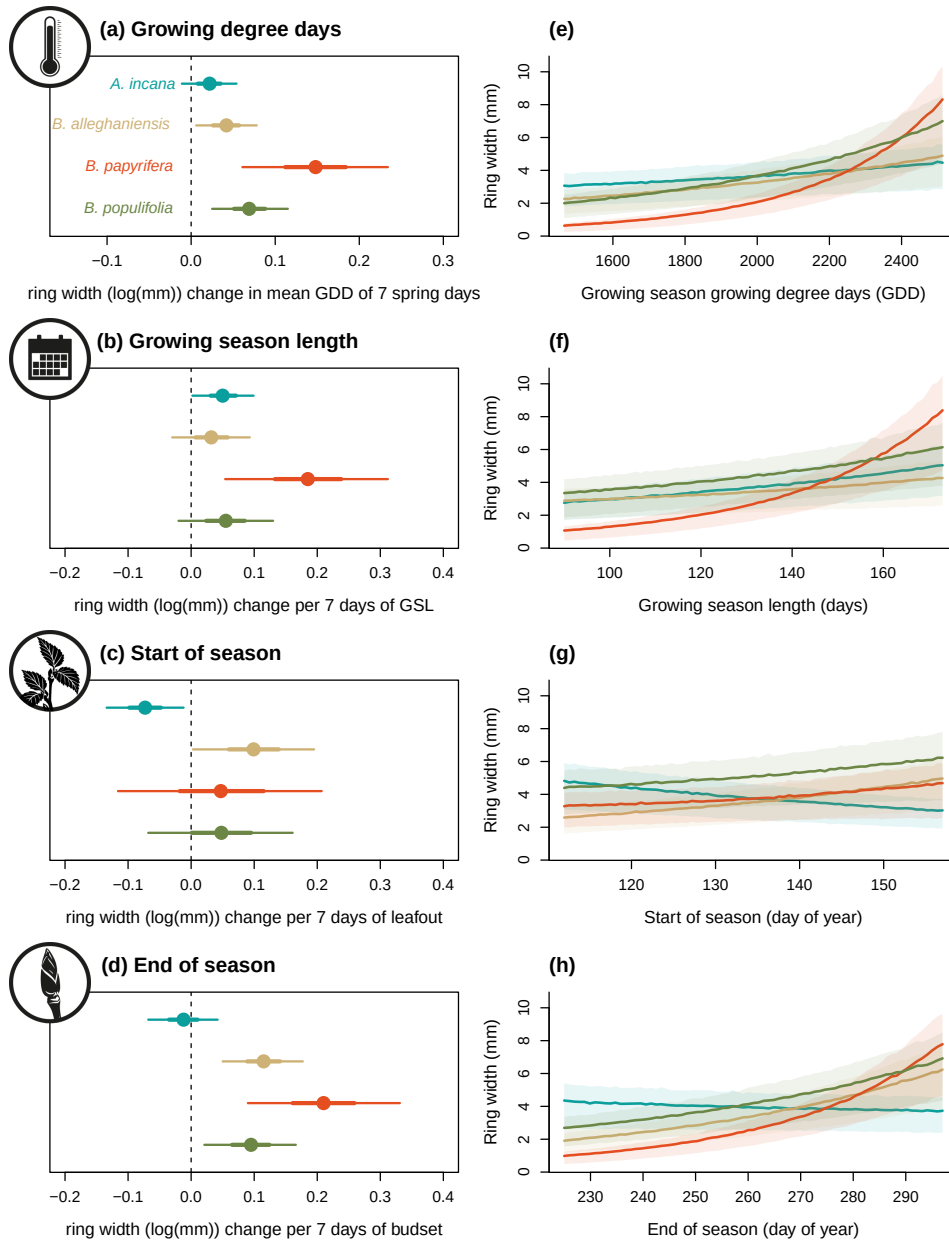


Figure 3: Estimates of ring width change as a function of four different phenological predictors: growing degree days of the growing season (mean daily temperature above 5°C); growing season length, start of season, and end of season across four species: Grey alder (*Alnus incana*), Yellow birch (*Betula alleghaniensis*), Paper birch (*Betula papyrifera*) and Grey birch (*Betula populifolia*; species colors are the same across the panels). Panels on the left (a to d) represent the mean model slope estimates for each species (dots) with 50% and 90% uncertainty intervals (thicker and thinner lines, respectively), for each predictor, which we represent through ring width change in mm on the log scale per adjusted predictor (see ‘Data analyses’ section in Methods for more details on predictor adjustment). Panels on the right (e to h) show the estimated response of ring width (mm) as a function of each predictor, with the lines depicting the mean response at each predictor value, and the shaded area, the 50% uncertainty intervals. See Tables S2, S3, S4 and S5 for parameter estimates.

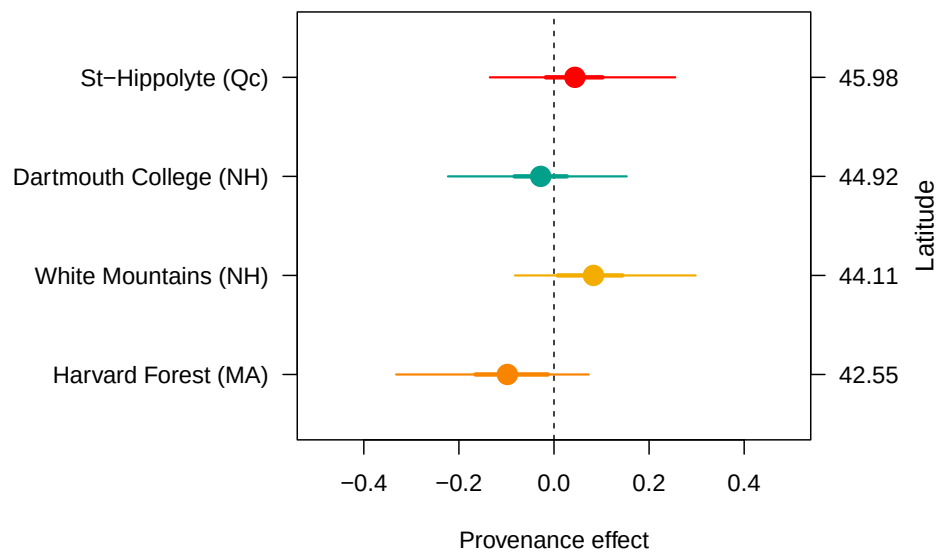


Figure 4: No effect of provenance on growth across a latitudinal gradient. We show the ring width ($\log(\text{mm})$; see Table S2 for provenance parameter estimates) for each provenance with growing degree days as the predictor (effects were similar for the other predictors, see Tables S3, S4, S5). The dots represent the estimated mean of each provenance, with 50% and 90% uncertainty intervals (thicker and thinner lines, respectively). The provenances are color-coded from Figure 2, the map showing their locations.

Discussion

Here we used 81 juvenile trees of four species from four provenances to study how longer growing seasons affect tree growth (using annual growth via tree rings and leaf phenology as a proxy for the start and end of season). Longer growing seasons increased growth for all species, but varied depending on the season metric used to measure it, with the thermal growing season more often relating to growth than the calendar season.

Our results support the idea that the thermal season is a better predictor for growth (Chuine & Régnière, 2017; Wang & Engel, 1998). By accounting for differences in daily temperatures, the thermal season may be more closely aligned to when and how fast plants can grow each day compared to the calendar season, which assumes a stable influence of each day on growth (Körner *et al.*, 2023). Thus, the short and cool spring days early in the season count for less in the thermal season than the calendar season (Buonaiuto *et al.*, 2026). Further supporting this, when we disentangled the calendar season by using the start and end of season separately, we found a larger response of growth to the end of season, with little effect of the start of season. The finding that the end of season appears more related to growth than the start of season is aligned with increasing work suggesting that the start and end of season together may dynamically determine growth (Zohner *et al.*, 2023). This implies that research focusing solely on the start of season (Dow *et al.*, 2022; Gao *et al.*, 2022; Wheeler *et al.*, 2016) could miss when longer seasons lead to more growth. The strong focus on the start of season in phenology research also implies that we may ignore an important part of the season for growth. While studies have long called for more research on the end of season (Gallinat *et al.*, 2015; Gunderson *et al.*, 2012; Piao *et al.*, 2019; Richardson *et al.*, 2012), our results suggest we may especially need more work that monitors how growth and phenology shift across the season (Zani *et al.*, 2020; Zohner *et al.*, 2023). More studies using data with a finer temporal scale (e.g., daily or weekly data through dendrometers and/or xylogenesis) could confirm if most growth occurs closer to the end versus the start of season. To date, these studies showed strong species differences in when most growth happens during the season. However, most of these studies were done on a small number of European and/or conifer species (e.g. Zweifel *et al.*, 2016; Etzold *et al.*, 2022; Balducci *et al.*, 2019), highlighting that we need more data across species spanning a wider range of life history strategies.

Our results suggest different growth strategies between species may yield different responses to longer seasons. Our most ruderal species, *A. incana* was the only species to grow more with a longer calendar season and an earlier start of season. This suggests that species with more ruderal, flexible life history strategies may actually take advantage of growing more in the spring despite cooler, shorter days (Bowman & Hacker, 2023; Furlow, 1997; Grime, 1977). In contrast, growth of *B. papyrifera* and *B. populifolia*, which are fast-growing but more conservative than *A. incana*, were both more driven by the end of season, suggesting that they may be able to exploit these late-season days characterized by warmer temperatures (Burns *et al.*, 1990). Lastly, our slowest growing, longest-living species, *B. alleghaniensis*, responded to both the start and end of season. This points towards a possible ‘neutralizing’ response where an early start of season decreases growth, but a later end of season increases it, muting this species’ response to a longer calendar season.

Studies including an even wider span of growth strategies across species may find further differences. Our four study species are all relatively fast-growing, which should allow them to track changing conditions better than their slower-growing counterparts. While we found an overall positive trend of warmer seasons on growth, this might have changed if we used slower-growing, more conservative species (such as *Quercus*; Burns *et al.*, 1990). Additionally, we used juvenile trees, which tend to be more reactive and could in part explain why they grew more with warmer seasons (Augsburger & Bartlett, 2003; Sweeney *et al.*, 2024). If these trees grew in a mature forest, they would have been below the canopy, competing for light and other resources and thus might not have responded as much as we observed in our competition-limited conditions (Polgar & Primack, 2011). We grew our trees in a common garden setting with potentially more space between trees (spacing was between 1.5 and 3 m), without any shade cloth. While other studies on mature trees have found the same response, our results may have been more muted if the trees were grown in a forest setting. However, our results may have implications beyond how mature forests function.

Our focus on juvenile trees may suggest how forests regenerate and assemble with the longer and warmer seasons of anthropogenic climate change. Plant phenology research has suggested that earlier seasons with warming favor species that shift earlier the most, with many studies focused on invasive species appearing

to support this (Wolkovich *et al.*, 2013; Zettlemoyer *et al.*, 2019). Yet, these studies are often on herbaceous species, and our results, along with other recent work (Zani *et al.*, 2020; Zohner *et al.*, 2023), suggest mid- and later-season effects may have underappreciated performance implications in woody species. Thus, more studies of how later season events correlate with invasions, and forest assembly more generally, could be especially important for understanding how warming will shift forest regeneration.

Our results also suggest assembly models may need less of a focus on population-level differences than previously suggested (Cavender-Bares, 2019). While studies of large latitudinal gradients have found lower growth in trees sourced from poleward latitudes (Aitken & Bemmels, 2016; Soolanayakanahally *et al.*, 2013), we found no differences in growth across a latitudinal gradient of 3.5°. Thus, at least across this latitudinal range, local adaptation on growth appears weak. Supporting this, we found no evidence of a shifting end of season across provenances, despite decades of work finding that end of season events, such as budset, are usually more locally adapted than start of season events such as leafout (Soolanayakanahally *et al.*, 2013; Zeng & Wolkovich, 2024). Further, a study of the same common garden including all tree and shrub species found that the end of season appeared to vary strongly by year and shift earlier with earlier start of season (Buonaiuto *et al.*, 2026), suggesting that the end of season may be more variable than currently proposed (Alberto *et al.*, 2013). Taken together, these results imply that our current understanding of budset being strongly locally adapted, and thus varying little with temperature or the start of season, needs more study.

Implications for large-scale vegetation modeling

Leveraging a rarely available dataset of tree growth coupled with leaf phenology start and end of season across provenances, we found an overall positive response from multiple tree species to warmer seasons, which has important implications for carbon models. While juvenile trees store little carbon compared to their adult forms, they are crucial for forest regeneration capacity and range expansion (as discussed above, and see Luu *et al.*, 2024). In addition to their ecological role, juvenile trees generally predict adult tree responses qualitatively (Augsburger & Bartlett, 2003; Wolkovich *et al.*, 2025), despite certain ontogenic differences in stress residence and mortality rate across life stages (Caron *et al.*, 2021). Thus our results on young trees can likely inform how their adult counterparts would have responded to changing growing season conditions.

We also found that the start and end of season asymmetrically matter to growth, which means that how we model these phenological events in vegetation and related earth system models may be critical for accurate predictions (Li *et al.*, 2022). These models usually assume a highly temperature-sensitive start of season and a more photoperiod-controlled, and thus less variable, end of season (Chen, 2022; Melaas *et al.*, 2016). This results in a disproportionate influence of the start compared to the end of season on tree growth, unlike what our results suggest. Such a representation of what drives the temporal boundaries of the growing season may feed into over-simplified explanations of the processes regulating tree growth with future climate change.

In addition, Melaas *et al.* (2016) pointed towards a weakness of land surface models in their lack of representation of species differences—which we show to be critical despite our species being closely related. Yet, most of these models still ignore this specific distinction that occurs between species, further misleading the relative effect of the start and end of season on carbon sequestration by forests (Melaas *et al.*, 2016; Harrison *et al.*, 2021). This could also mislead which ecosystems to target for conservation and restoration as natural climate solutions (Ruehr *et al.*, 2023; Chang *et al.*, 2024). Thus, better modelling approaches of the start and end of season will require more studies, especially on more species across a larger gradient. Alongside improving land surface models, such studies could help tease out whether local adaptation of the end of season depends on the species, latitudinal range (both distance and how far north provenances come from), or some combination of the two.

Integrating our results into models will also require considering how environmental conditions beyond temperature shift across the season, especially soil moisture (Gao *et al.*, 2022; Li *et al.*, 2023). Trees in our common garden were regularly watered, likely relieving any major drought pressures, though studies beyond ours have found a connection between later end of season and more growth (see: Gao *et al.*, 2022; Wang *et al.*, 2025). For the four species we studied, there are currently no increases in drought occurrence within their ranges (National Centers for Environmental Information (NCEI), 2026; Agel *et al.*, 2025), suggesting that their growth may increase with longer and warmer growing seasons (Cook & Pederson, 2011; Agel

et al., 2025), as we found. However, the positive effect of a later end of season could be offset if soil moisture becomes inadequate for growth, and other temperate regions with decreased soil moisture have reported declines in tree growth (e.g., Chiang *et al.*, 2021; Spinoni *et al.*, 2018). Improved accuracy of future carbon sequestration models would consequently require integrating over more regions and growth drivers.

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Supplemental material

Table S1: Provenance coordinates and count per species and provenances out of a total of 81 individual trees sampled from the United States of America (in Massachusetts (MA) and New Hampshire(NH)) and Canada (in Quebec (Qc)).

Provenance	Longitude	Latitude	<i>A. incana</i> (<i>n</i> = 29)	<i>B. alleghaniensis</i> (<i>n</i> = 20)	<i>B. papyrifera</i> (<i>n</i> = 7)	<i>B. populifolia</i> (<i>n</i> = 25)
Harvard Forest (MA)	-72.2	42.5	7	0	4	7
White Mountains (NH)	-71.0	44.1	6	7	0	9
Dartmouth College (NH)	-70.7	44.9	8	7	2	9
St-Hippolyte (Qc)	-74.0	46.0	8	6	1	0

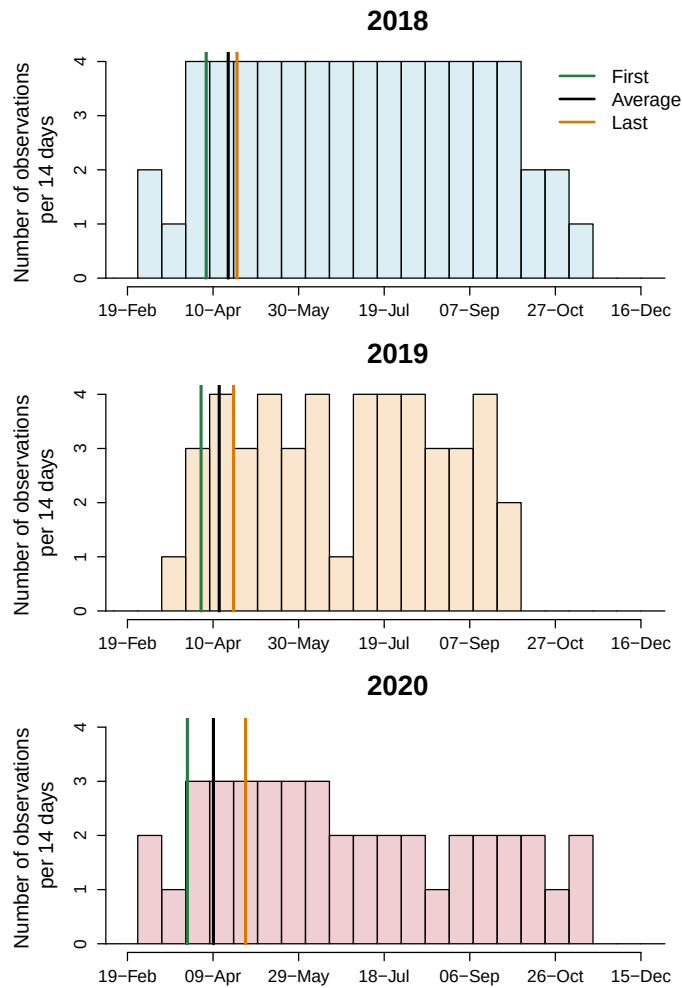


Figure S1: Leaf phenology monitoring frequency across years. We monitored leaf phenology once or twice per week for three years, though the frequency varied within and across years. Each histogram bin represents the number of observations that were made during a period of 14 days and the lines represent the earliest, the average and last recorded budburst observations. This demonstrates that across the different frequencies of observation, distances between early spring phenophases were similar across years.

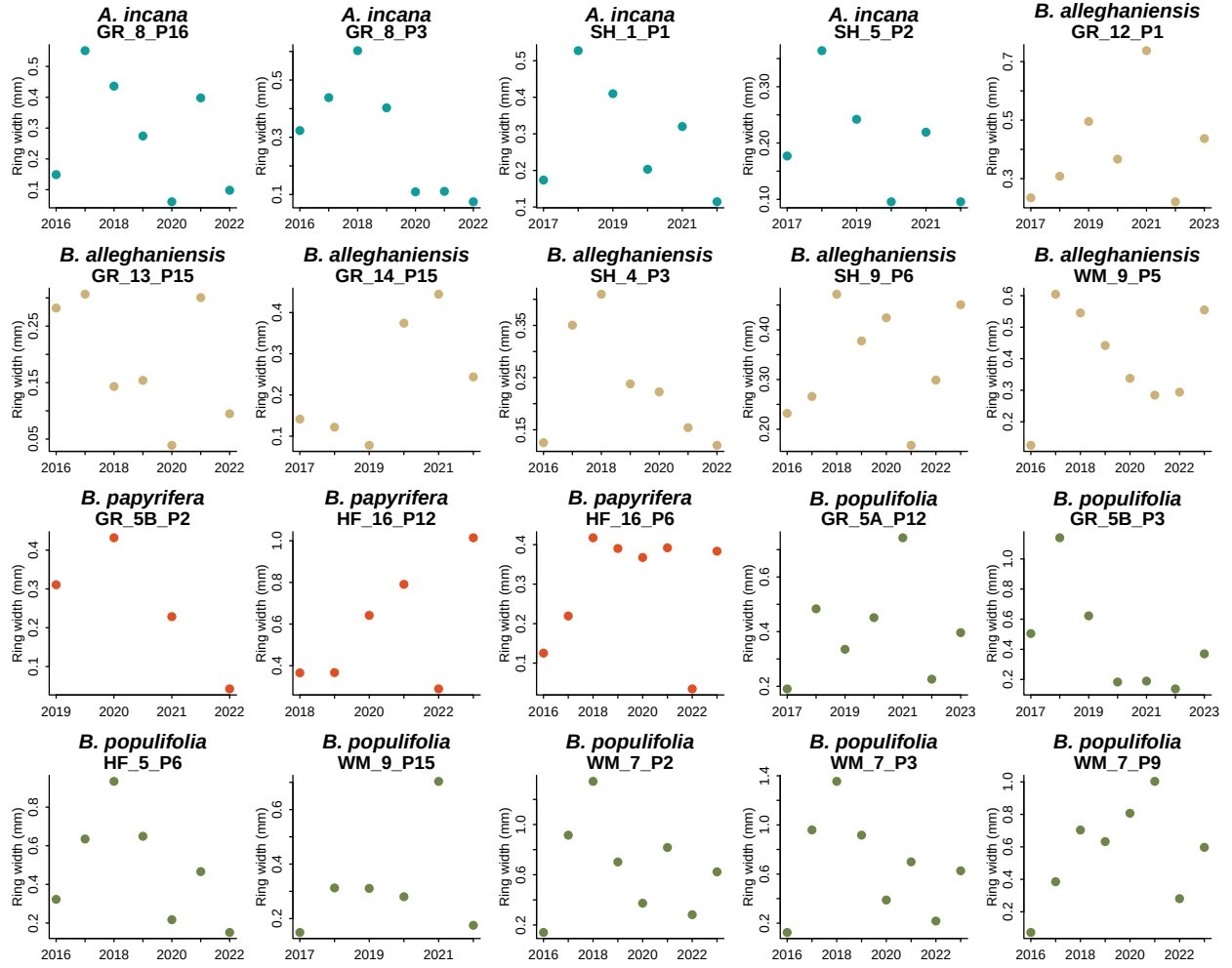


Figure S2: We show the potential allometry patterns across all years we had ring width for. For this, we randomly sampled 20 trees from our dataset and represent their ring width (mm) for each year.

Table S2: Summary output of each parameter for the growing degree days (GDD) predictor of ring width (log(mm)). We report estimates as mean and 90% and 50% uncertainty intervals. See ‘Data analyses’ in Methods section for more details.

Parameter	Mean	5%	25%	75%	95%
α	-0.57	-4.61	-2.30	1.14	3.57
$\sigma_{\alpha_{treeid}}$	0.17	0.05	0.13	0.21	0.27
$\sigma_{\alpha_{prov}}$	0.18	0.02	0.08	0.22	0.48
σ_y	0.48	0.43	0.46	0.50	0.53
$\beta_{species A. incana}$	0.02	-0.01	0.01	0.04	0.05
$\beta_{species B. alleghaniensis}$	0.04	0.01	0.03	0.06	0.08
$\beta_{species B. papyrifera}$	0.15	0.06	0.11	0.18	0.23
$\beta_{species B. populi folia}$	0.07	0.03	0.05	0.09	0.12
$\alpha_{prov Dartmouth College (NH)}$	-0.03	-0.22	-0.08	0.03	0.15
$\alpha_{prov Harvard Forest (MA)}$	-0.10	-0.33	-0.17	-0.01	0.07
$\alpha_{prov St-Hippolyte (Qc)}$	0.04	-0.14	-0.02	0.10	0.26
$\alpha_{prov White Mountains (NH)}$	0.08	-0.08	0.01	0.14	0.30
$\alpha_{year 2018}$	0.17	-0.77	-0.22	0.56	1.14
$\alpha_{year 2019}$	0.16	-0.78	-0.24	0.55	1.12
$\alpha_{year 2020}$	-0.45	-1.39	-0.85	-0.06	0.51
$\alpha_{species A. incana}$	1.01	-3.14	-0.69	2.74	5.18
$\alpha_{species B. alleghaniensis}$	0.15	-4.04	-1.58	1.88	4.24
$\alpha_{species B. papyrifera}$	-4.04	-9.02	-6.09	-2.03	0.89
$\alpha_{species B. populi folia}$	-0.70	-5.04	-2.52	1.11	3.50

Table S3: Summary output of each parameter for the growing season length (GSL) predictor of ring width (log(mm)). We report estimates as mean and 90% and 50% uncertainty intervals. See ‘Data analyses’ in Methods section for more details.

Parameter	Mean	5%	25%	75%	95%
α	0.17	-3.84	-1.48	1.83	4.16
$\sigma_{\alpha_{treeid}}$	0.18	0.05	0.14	0.22	0.28
$\sigma_{\alpha_{prov}}$	0.18	0.02	0.07	0.22	0.48
σ_y	0.48	0.44	0.46	0.50	0.53
$\beta_{species A. incana}$	0.05	0.00	0.03	0.07	0.10
$\beta_{species B. alleghaniensis}$	0.03	-0.03	0.01	0.06	0.09
$\beta_{species B. papyrifera}$	0.18	0.05	0.13	0.24	0.31
$\beta_{species B. populi folia}$	0.06	-0.02	0.02	0.09	0.13
$\alpha_{prov Dartmouth College (NH)}$	-0.04	-0.24	-0.09	0.02	0.15
$\alpha_{prov Harvard Forest (MA)}$	-0.09	-0.32	-0.15	-0.01	0.08
$\alpha_{prov St-Hippolyte (Qc)}$	0.04	-0.15	-0.02	0.10	0.25
$\alpha_{prov White Mountains (NH)}$	0.08	-0.08	0.01	0.14	0.30
$\alpha_{year 2018}$	0.22	-0.71	-0.16	0.61	1.16
$\alpha_{year 2019}$	0.09	-0.86	-0.29	0.48	1.03
$\alpha_{year 2020}$	-0.35	-1.29	-0.74	0.03	0.58
$\alpha_{species A. incana}$	0.09	-3.97	-1.59	1.75	4.17
$\alpha_{species B. alleghaniensis}$	0.33	-3.79	-1.34	1.99	4.40
$\alpha_{species B. papyrifera}$	-2.71	-7.18	-4.56	-0.89	1.78
$\alpha_{species B. populi folia}$	0.18	-3.92	-1.54	1.92	4.33

Table S4: Summary output of each parameter for the start of season (SOS) predictor of ring width (log(mm)). We report estimates as mean and 90% and 50% uncertainty intervals. See ‘Data analyses’ in Methods section for more details.

Parameter	Mean	5%	25%	75%	95%
α	1.08	-2.52	-0.44	2.56	4.77
$\sigma_{\alpha_{treeid}}$	0.21	0.11	0.18	0.25	0.30
$\sigma_{\alpha_{prov}}$	0.16	0.01	0.07	0.20	0.47
σ_y	0.47	0.43	0.45	0.49	0.52
$\beta_{speciesA.incana}$	-0.07	-0.13	-0.10	-0.05	-0.01
$\beta_{speciesB.alleganiensis}$	0.10	0.00	0.06	0.14	0.20
$\beta_{speciesB.papyrifera}$	0.05	-0.12	-0.02	0.12	0.21
$\beta_{speciesB.populifolia}$	0.05	-0.07	0.00	0.10	0.16
$\alpha_{provDartmouthCollege(NH)}$	-0.06	-0.27	-0.12	0.00	0.09
$\alpha_{provHarvardForest(MA)}$	-0.04	-0.25	-0.10	0.01	0.12
$\alpha_{provSt-Hippolyte(Qc)}$	0.02	-0.16	-0.03	0.08	0.21
$\alpha_{provWhiteMountains(NH)}$	0.08	-0.07	0.01	0.14	0.30
$\alpha_{year2018}$	0.21	-0.75	-0.17	0.59	1.18
$\alpha_{year2019}$	0.12	-0.84	-0.26	0.49	1.08
$\alpha_{year2020}$	-0.37	-1.34	-0.76	0.01	0.59
$\alpha_{speciesA.incana}$	1.55	-2.16	0.10	3.03	5.10
$\alpha_{speciesB.alleganiensis}$	-1.85	-5.62	-3.39	-0.27	1.90
$\alpha_{speciesB.papyrifera}$	-0.74	-5.04	-2.46	0.99	3.48
$\alpha_{speciesB.populifolia}$	-0.47	-4.33	-2.02	1.12	3.31

Table S5: Summary output of each parameter for the end of season (EOS) predictor of ring width (log(mm)). We report estimates as mean and 90% and 50% uncertainty intervals. See ‘Data analyses’ in Methods section for more details.

Parameter	Mean	5%	25%	75%	95%
α	-1.40	-5.52	-3.10	0.32	2.70
$\sigma_{\alpha_{treeid}}$	0.19	0.07	0.15	0.23	0.28
$\sigma_{\alpha_{prov}}$	0.18	0.02	0.07	0.22	0.49
σ_y	0.47	0.42	0.45	0.49	0.52
$\beta_{speciesA.incana}$	-0.01	-0.07	-0.04	0.01	0.04
$\beta_{speciesB.alleganiensis}$	0.12	0.05	0.09	0.14	0.18
$\beta_{speciesB.papyrifera}$	0.21	0.09	0.16	0.26	0.33
$\beta_{speciesB.populifolia}$	0.10	0.02	0.07	0.12	0.17
$\alpha_{provDartmouthCollege(NH)}$	-0.04	-0.23	-0.09	0.02	0.14
$\alpha_{provHarvardForest(MA)}$	-0.09	-0.33	-0.15	-0.01	0.07
$\alpha_{provSt-Hippolyte(Qc)}$	0.04	-0.14	-0.02	0.10	0.25
$\alpha_{provWhiteMountains(NH)}$	0.07	-0.09	0.01	0.14	0.28
$\alpha_{year2018}$	0.23	-0.70	-0.16	0.62	1.17
$\alpha_{year2019}$	0.11	-0.82	-0.28	0.51	1.07
$\alpha_{year2020}$	-0.48	-1.41	-0.88	-0.09	0.47
$\alpha_{speciesA.incana}$	3.18	-1.27	1.40	4.95	7.54
$\alpha_{speciesB.alleganiensis}$	-1.74	-6.24	-3.57	0.13	2.73
$\alpha_{speciesB.papyrifera}$	-5.50	-11.08	-7.83	-3.20	0.08
$\alpha_{speciesB.populifolia}$	-0.75	-5.40	-2.60	1.11	3.84

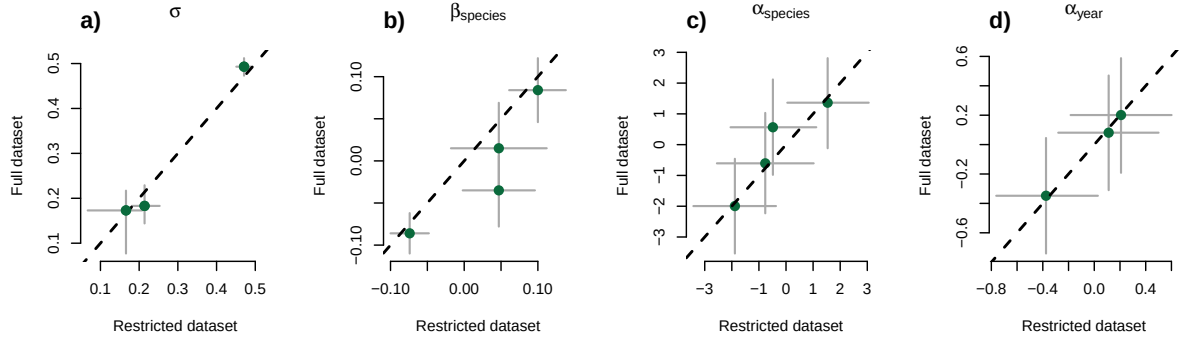
Table S6: Summary output of each parameter from our GDD (growing degree days) model, using basal area increment ($\log(mm^2)$) as the response variable. We report estimates as mean and 90% and 50% uncertainty intervals. See ‘Data analyses’ in Methods section for more details.

Parameter	Mean	5%	25%	75%	95%
α	0.62	-4.52	-1.50	2.77	5.84
$\sigma_{\alpha_{treeid}}$	0.52	0.41	0.47	0.56	0.64
$\sigma_{\alpha_{prov}}$	0.27	0.03	0.12	0.35	0.73
σ_y	0.63	0.57	0.61	0.66	0.70
$\beta_{speciesA.incana}$	0.11	-0.03	0.05	0.17	0.25
$\beta_{speciesB.alleganiensis}$	0.20	0.02	0.13	0.26	0.36
$\beta_{speciesB.papyrifera}$	0.92	0.49	0.74	1.10	1.34
$\beta_{speciesB.populifolia}$	0.41	0.20	0.32	0.49	0.61
$\alpha_{siteDartmouthCollege(NH)}$	-0.11	-0.47	-0.20	0.00	0.17
$\alpha_{siteHarvardForest(MA)}$	-0.09	-0.45	-0.18	0.02	0.19
$\alpha_{siteSt-Hippolyte(Qc)}$	0.06	-0.23	-0.04	0.15	0.42
$\alpha_{siteWhiteMountains(NH)}$	0.15	-0.11	0.02	0.26	0.52
$\alpha_{year2018}$	-0.36	-1.32	-0.77	0.03	0.61
$\alpha_{year2019}$	0.33	-0.65	-0.07	0.73	1.32
$\alpha_{year2020}$	-0.04	-1.01	-0.44	0.35	0.94
$\alpha_{speciesA.incana}$	3.23	-2.25	0.98	5.48	8.55
$\alpha_{speciesB.alleganiensis}$	2.09	-3.40	-0.16	4.34	7.54
$\alpha_{speciesB.papyrifera}$	-7.59	-14.84	-10.57	-4.73	-0.29
$\alpha_{speciesB.populifolia}$	-0.07	-5.98	-2.41	2.29	5.57

Table S7: Summary output (β) of our GDD parameters (see Table S2 for untransformed parameter estimates), converted in % for a predicted extension in the start and end of season across, and for each species. We report estimates as posterior means with 90% and 50% uncertainty intervals.

Parameter	Mean	5%	25%	75%	95%
β_{SOS}	7.16	4.10	5.88	8.38	10.31
β_{EOS}	10.69	6.11	8.76	12.51	15.48
$\beta_{SOSA.incana}$	1.72	-0.84	0.64	2.79	4.32
$\beta_{SOSB.alleganiensis}$	4.49	0.58	2.78	6.15	8.51
$\beta_{SOSB.papyrifera}$	16.11	6.27	11.90	20.25	26.47
$\beta_{SOSB.populifolia}$	6.31	2.19	4.54	7.98	10.63
$\beta_{EOSA.incana}$	3.02	-1.46	1.12	4.90	7.63
$\beta_{EOSB.alleganiensis}$	7.18	0.92	4.41	9.85	13.71
$\beta_{EOSB.papyrifera}$	22.58	8.61	16.50	28.46	37.58
$\beta_{EOSB.populifolia}$	9.99	3.42	7.13	12.67	16.99

Start of season (SOS)



End of season (EOS)

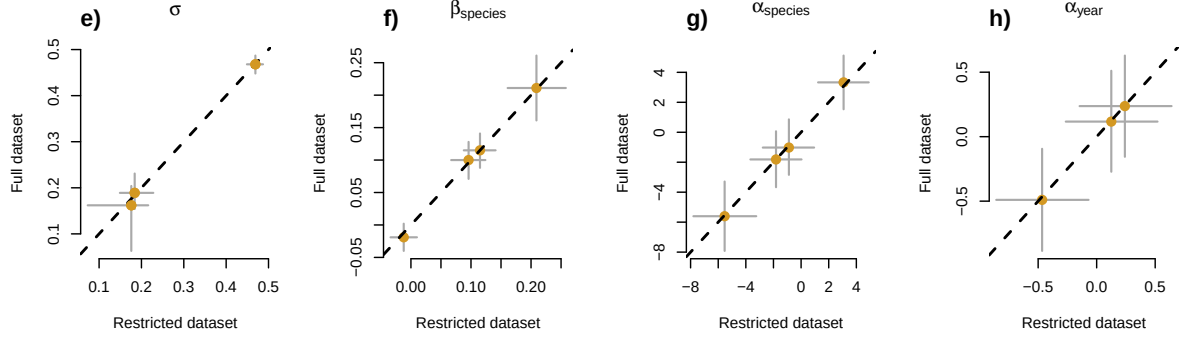


Figure S3: Full vs most restricted datasets for the model with start of season (a-d) and end of season (d-h) as the predictor. Each panel represent the different parameters used to fit the models. σ (a, e), $\alpha_{species}$ (c, g) and α_{year} (d, h) represent the ring width (log(mm)) for species and year, respectively. $\beta_{species}$ (b, f) represent the change in ring width (log(mm))/adjusted predictor, for each species (see 'Data analyses' section in Methods for more details).

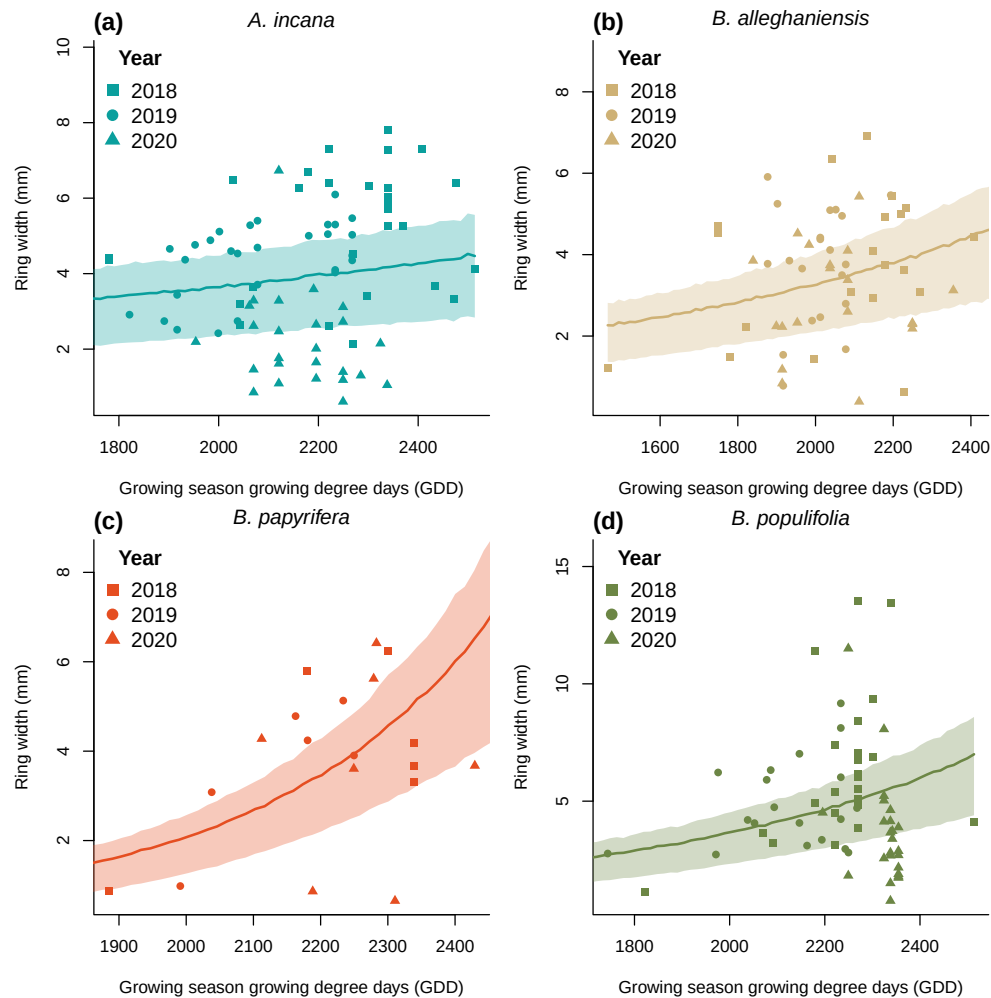


Figure S4: Ring width (mm) trends in response to thermal season (growing degree days). The lines represent the mean of the posterior distribution and the shaded area, the 50% uncertainty intervals at each predictor value back-converted from the model which uses ring width in log(mm) as the response variable. The dots are the empirical data shaped by year.

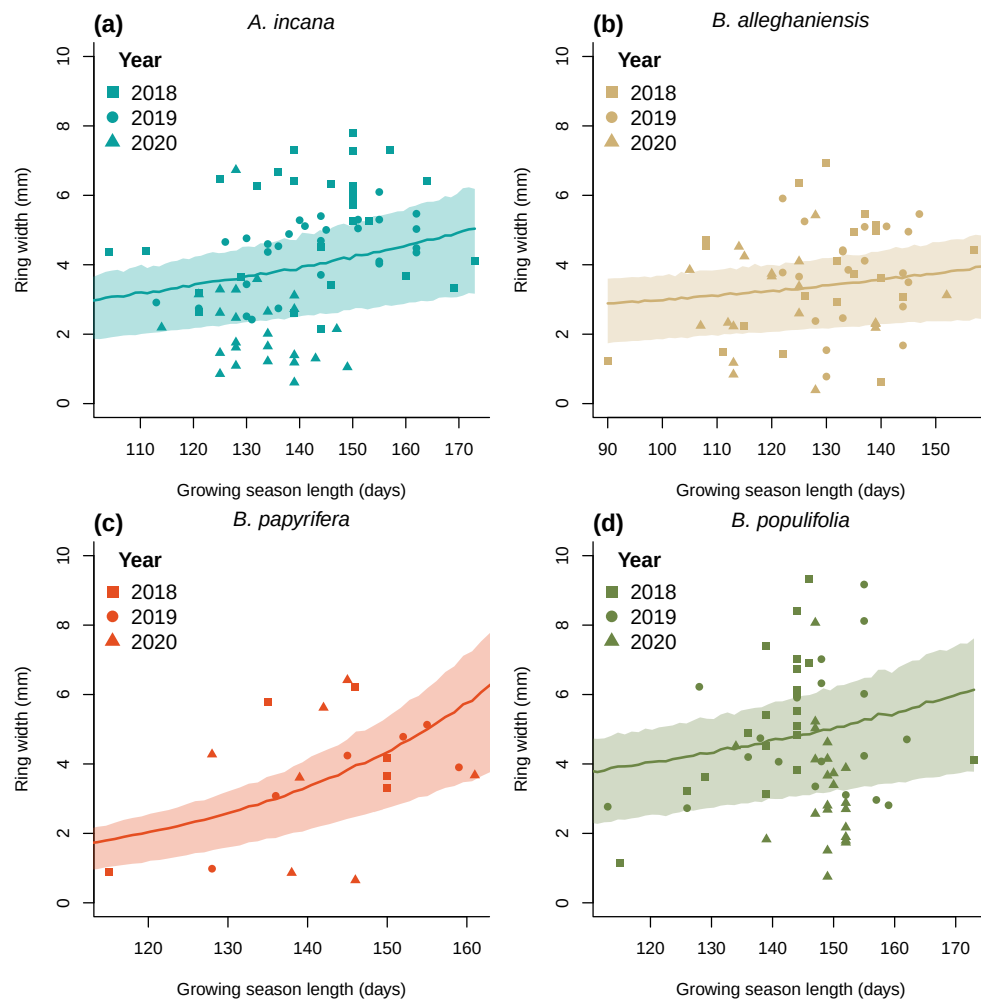


Figure S5: Ring width trends (mm) in response to calendar season (growing season length). The lines represent the mean of the posterior distribution and the shaded area, the 50% uncertainty intervals at each predictor value back-converted from the model which uses ring width in $\log(\text{mm})$ as the response variable. The dots are the empirical data shaped by year.

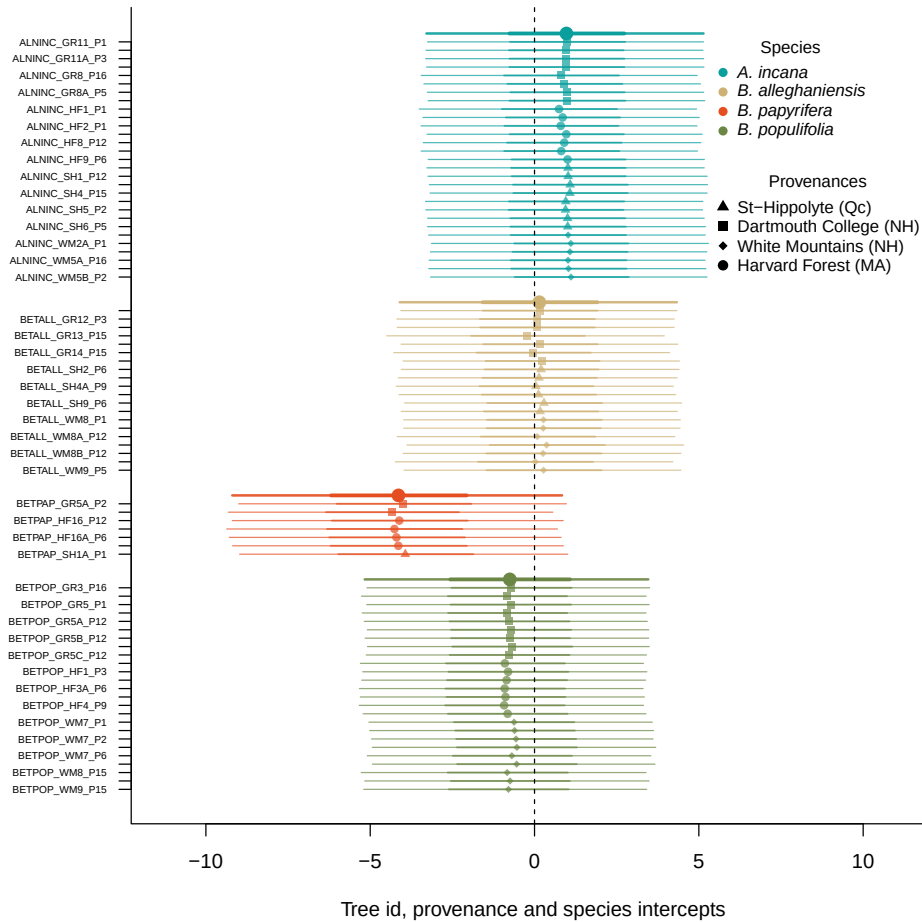


Figure S6: Ring width (log(mm)) deviations from the grand mean for grouping factor of the GDD model. The different tree id values represent the combined intercepts of tree id, provenance, species and averaged year intercepts. The larger dots and lines represent the species intercepts which are the species level estimates averaged across all of their tree ids. The dots are the mean of the posterior distribution and the thick and thin lines, the 50 and 90% uncertainty intervals.

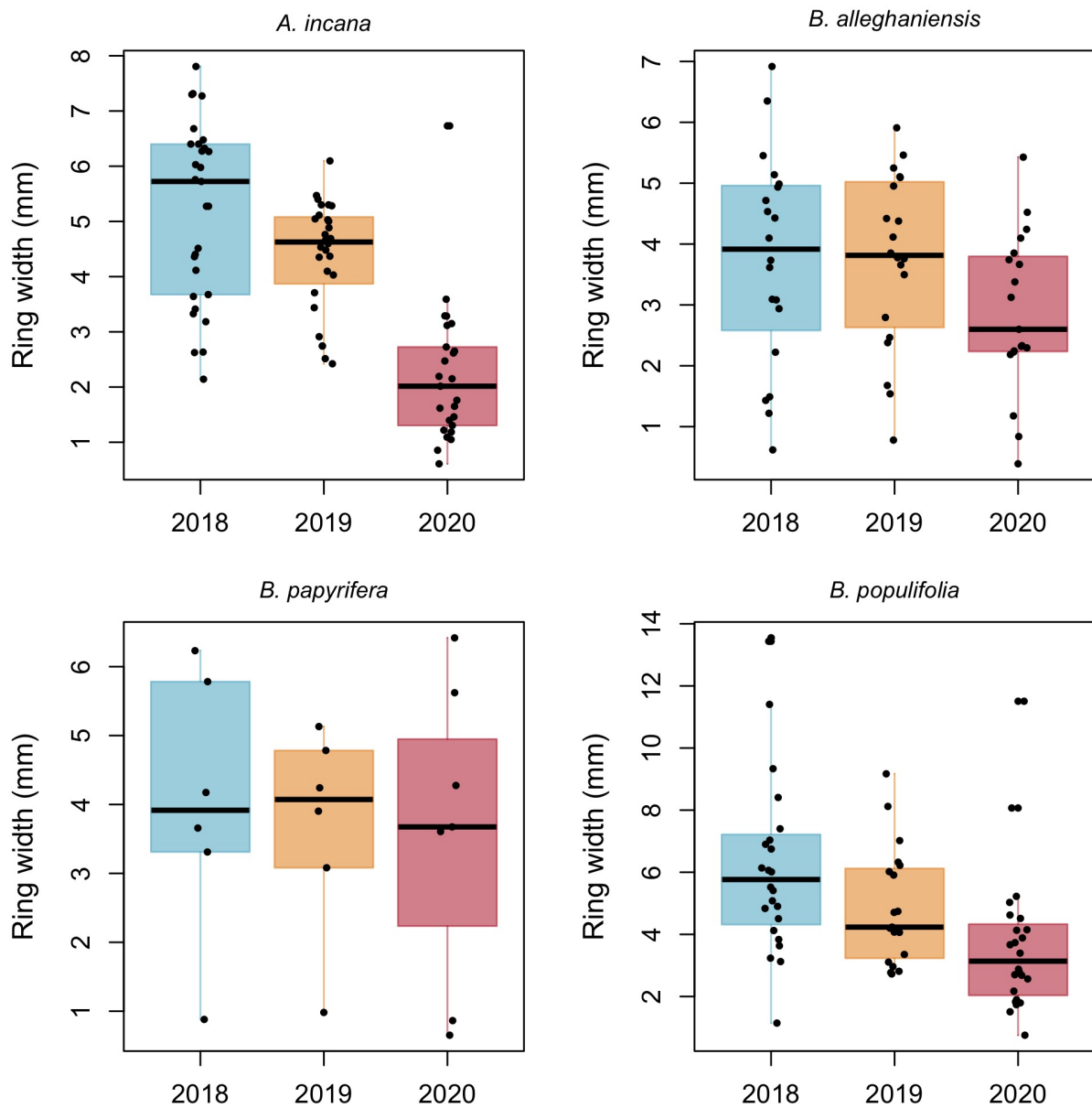


Figure S7: Boxplots representing the empirical data of our ring widths (mm) separated by species. The dots represent the raw data, the line is the mean and the box depicts the 50% uncertainty intervals.

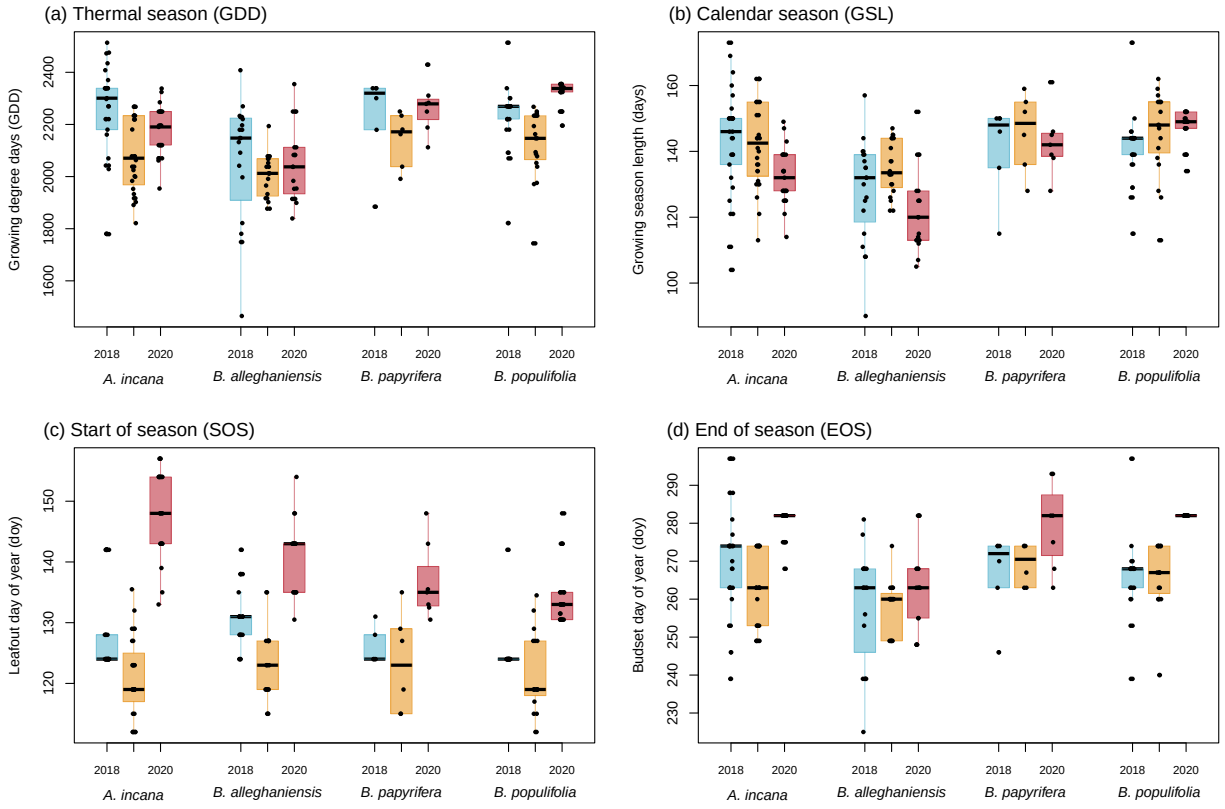


Figure S8: Boxplots representing the empirical data of all our predictors clustered by species, and for each year. The dots represent the raw data, the line is the mean and the box depicts the 50% uncertainty intervals.

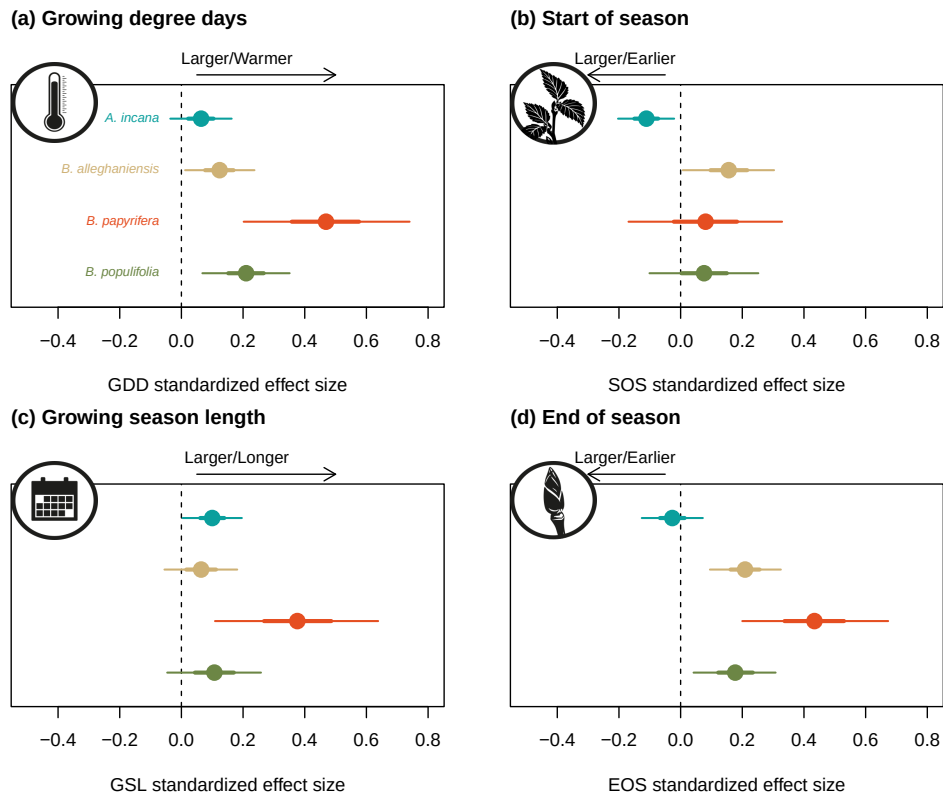


Figure S9: Effect size of each predictor across our four species. We depict ring width (log(mm)) change per adjusted predictor (z -scored; see 'Data analyses' section in Methods for more details) for each species. We report estimates as mean and 90% uncertainty intervals across our four different predictors (growing degree days, growing season length, start of season and end of season).

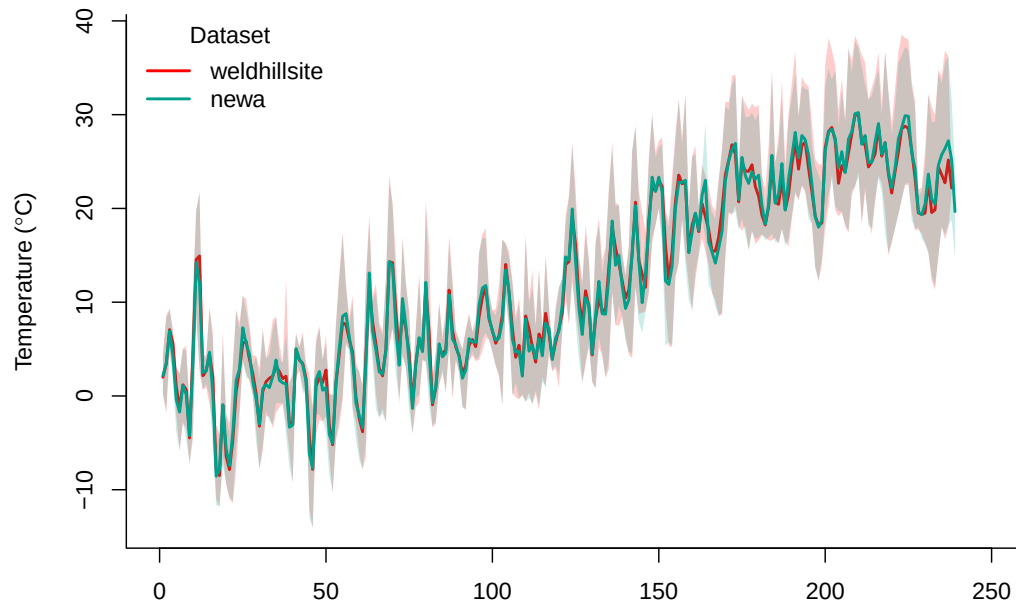


Figure S10: Climate data overlap in 2020 for the two climate stations we used in our dataset (see ‘Data analyses’ section for more details). The lines represent the daily mean temperature of each climate station and the shaded area, the minimum and maximum daily temperatures.